Nauvoo

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How religious refugees built one of Illinois's largest cities in a few short years — and how a printing press, a jail, and a mob ended it.

A city on a bend in the river

In 1839 a few thousand members of a new American faith — the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, or Mormons — arrived in western Illinois as refugees. They had just been driven out of Missouri, where the governor had issued an extermination order and a mob had killed seventeen of them at Haun's Mill. Illinois, for the moment, welcomed them.

They bought a swampy bend in the Mississippi called Commerce, drained it, and renamed it Nauvoo — a Hebrew-derived word their prophet, Joseph Smith, translated as "a beautiful place." Within five years it had grown to some 12,000 people, rivaling Chicago for the title of largest city in the state.

Nauvoo on the Mississippi — view of the Latter-day Saint city, 1840s. Public domain.

Joseph Smith

Joseph Smith had founded the church in New York in 1830 on the strength of the Book of Mormon, which he said he had translated from golden plates. To his followers he was a prophet who spoke for God; to many outsiders he was a fraud, and his church a dangerous cult. Both reactions followed the Mormons everywhere they went.

At Nauvoo, Smith was not only the church's prophet but the city's mayor, and the lieutenant general of its militia. That concentration of religious, political, and military power in one man is central to everything that happened next.

Joseph Smith Jr. (1805–1844), founder of the Latter-day Saint movement — portrait, public domain.

A city that governed itself

The Illinois legislature — both parties courting the Mormon vote — granted Nauvoo an extraordinarily generous charter in 1840. The city could run its own courts, found its own university, and raise its own militia: the Nauvoo Legion, which grew to several thousand men, one of the largest armed forces in the state outside the U.S. Army.

To the Mormons, this was simply the self-government a persecuted people needed to stay safe. To their neighbors, it looked like a state within a state — a theocracy with its own army, voting in a disciplined bloc that could swing any election. Fear grew with the city.

The Nauvoo Legion — the city's own militia, thousands strong. Period illustration, public domain.

The place, and the friction it bred

Nauvoo sat on a horseshoe bend of the Mississippi at the far western edge of Illinois, in thinly settled Hancock County — roughly 250 miles from the state capital and about 18 miles from the county seat at Carthage. On a sparsely populated frontier, a city that swelled to 12,000 in five years did not merely join the county; it became its center of gravity, almost overnight.

That sudden weight is the root of the trouble. The Mormons voted as a bloc, which let them swing elections and made both parties court and then resent them. They drilled a private army, the Nauvoo Legion. Their city charter gave them courts that could shield their own from outside warrants. They kept their business among themselves. And by the early 1840s, rumors spread — denied in public, true in fact — that leaders practiced plural marriage.

None of this made the violence that followed deserved — it did not. But it built the fear, and fear is the raw material of what happened next.

Nauvoo sat on a horseshoe bend of the Mississippi at the far western edge of Illinois, in Hancock County — about 18 miles from the county seat at Carthage and some 250 miles from the capital at Springfield. State outline: usaLow (public domain). Map © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

The press they destroyed

In June 1844, a group of Mormon dissenters — former insiders who had broken with Smith — started a newspaper, the Nauvoo Expositor, to expose plural marriage and what they called Smith's abuse of power. It printed exactly one issue, on June 7.

Three days later, the Nauvoo city council — with Smith presiding as mayor — declared the paper a public nuisance and ordered the marshal to destroy the press. The type was scattered in the street. Whatever the paper had printed, a government had just smashed a newspaper it disliked — and that, not polygamy, was the spark that lit the state.

The Nauvoo Expositor, June 7, 1844 — it published one issue. Reproduction, public domain.

"Freedom of the press"

The reaction was immediate and enormous. Newspapers across Illinois thundered that Smith had trampled the First Amendment. To his enemies, the destruction of the Expositor was proof of everything they had claimed: that Nauvoo was a tyranny that put itself above the Constitution. Calls went out to raise a mob and drive the Mormons from the state.

Smith declared martial law in Nauvoo and called out the Legion — which only confirmed the fears. The governor of Illinois, Thomas Ford, rode to the scene and persuaded Smith to surrender to the law and stand trial, promising him the state's protection.

The jail

Joseph Smith and his brother Hyrum were jailed at Carthage, the county seat, to await trial. Governor Ford left for Nauvoo, taking most of the guard and leaving the Smiths behind thinner protection than he had promised.

On the evening of June 27, 1844, a mob of some 200 men — many of them militia with their faces blackened — stormed the jail. Hyrum was shot first and killed. Joseph, who had a smuggled pistol, fired back, then was hit and fell from a second-story window. Both brothers were dead. The prophet his followers had believed God protected had been murdered by a mob, in the custody of the state that had promised him safety.

Carthage Jail (south front), where Joseph and Hyrum Smith were held and killed — stereoview, Underwood & Underwood, 1904. Public domain.

Driven west

The murders did not end the conflict; they inflamed it. The state repealed Nauvoo's charter, anti-Mormon violence continued, and it became clear the Mormons could not stay. Under their new leader, Brigham Young, most of the community abandoned the city they had built and, beginning in the winter of 1846, set out across Iowa toward the Rocky Mountains — the exodus that would end at the Great Salt Lake.

They left behind their great limestone temple, finished just as they were leaving; within a few years it was burned by an arsonist and toppled by a tornado. A city of 12,000 emptied almost overnight.

Crossing the Mississippi on the Ice — the Latter-day Saints leaving Nauvoo in the winter of 1846. Painting by C.C.A. Christensen, c. 1878, public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Persecution, in a free state

Nauvoo is not a story about a faraway place or a distant century. It happened in Illinois, to Americans, under the U.S. Constitution — a religious minority welcomed, then feared, then killed and expelled, while the machinery of law looked on or joined in. It sits uneasily beside the country's promise of religious freedom, and it is meant to.

It also hands you a genuinely hard question, not a comfortable one — because the thing that lit the fuse was a city destroying a newspaper. Scroll down and decide what you think the law should have done.